



northern states are very talkative. In some states, the ultimate goal is simply to make the Indian team, while others who have more representation are thinking of the Olympic medal. So, we have to find a balance when we are in the team. I think people really underestimate how big India is and how hard it is to make a team," he says.

However, it's that knowledge of how special being part of an Indian team is — and all it represents — that keeps Hardik motivated.

"I didn't choose hockey because I wanted fame or money. I chose it because I enjoyed it. It helped that I was from a hockey family and that I had that in my mind from a very young age. Even when there was the lockdown [due to Covid-19], there would be talk that other sports have so much money, but when I saw how

Indians celebrated India's win at the Olympics, that boosted my passion even more. Even when I was thinking that I wish I had won a gold, I know the value of this bronze. After we won in Tokyo, I had a friend of mine who said one senior relative of his wanted to speak to me. When uncle came on the call, he told me, '*Beta, humari ek generation chali gayi, humne medal nahi dekha.*' (We had gone one generation without seeing an Olympic medal.) Thanks to you, I have seen India stand on the Olympic podium once before I passed.' That's when it really hit home that people love this medal and value it so much. That a person was crying on the phone while speaking to me," he says.

But while he might have already inspired many, Hardik says his task won't be completed until he actually

Playful bond: Hardik Singh brings the game home, playing fetch with his German Shepherd, Marshal — a hockey ball and stick still in play.

R. V. MOORTHY

wins an Olympic gold for India.

"No matter what we achieved, we haven't achieved what those teams from the 1975 World Championships or the 1980 Olympics have done. I feel proud that I've inspired people, but I don't think we have done enough. We have won two medals, but still we didn't win the Olympic gold and we were not world champions. That's my ambition. I want to take India to a place where it once was. And just like how others inspired me, if I can inspire five or six other players, that would be special," he says.